

The **Battle of Hippo Regius** was a naval encounter during [Caesar's Civil War](#) which occurred off the coast of the [African](#) city of [Hippo Regius](#) in 46 BC. [Metellus Scipio](#) and a number of influential [senators](#) from the [Optimate](#) faction were fleeing the disastrous [Battle of Thapsus](#) when their fleet was intercepted and destroyed by [Publius Sittius](#), a mercenary commander in the employ of the Mauretanian king [Bocchus](#), an ally of [Gaius Julius Caesar's](#). Scipio committed suicide and all of the other senators were killed during the battle.

Background

Further information: [Caesar's Civil War](#), [Crossing the Rubicon](#), [Battle of Pharsalus](#), [Siege of Alexandria \(47 BC\)](#), and [Battle of Thapsus](#)

Escalating tensions over the previous decade between [Gaius Julius Caesar](#) and the [Roman Senate](#), rallying around [Gnaeus Pompeius Magnus](#) ("Pompey the Great"), culminated in Caesar [crossing the Rubicon](#) river in January 49 BC and thus being labelled as an enemy of the people.^[1] With civil war ignited Caesar quickly gained control of the Italian Peninsula before eventually pursuing Pompey to Greece and defeating him in the [Battle of Pharsalus](#).^[2] Pompey was assassinated as he attempted to flee to [Ptolemaic Egypt](#) precipitating Caesar's intervention in an [ongoing civil war](#). After a year spent in [Alexandria](#), Caesar began to coordinate his efforts against the remaining [Optimate](#) forces concentrated in the north of [Africa](#).

After landing in Africa, the Optimates gathered to confront Caesar as he besieged the city of [Thapsus](#). The force arrayed against Caesar was commanded primarily by [Metellus Scipio](#), who had taken this eminent position following the death of Pompey the Great. The ensuing [battle](#) was a disaster for Scipio and his numerically superior army was completely routed by Caesar.

Prelude

[Publius Sittius](#) became a mercenary in Northern Africa after being implicated in the [Second Catilinarian Conspiracy](#) of 63 BC. He had become involved in the civil war while in the employ of [Bocchus II](#) of eastern [Mauretania](#) together they had organised an invasion into the lands of [Massinissa II](#) and quickly captured his kingdom. This kingdom was an ally of [Juba I](#) of [Numidia](#) who was in turn an ally of Scipio. At this time Juba was moving to rendezvous with Scipio and confront Caesar at [Thapsus](#) but upon learning that Sittius' was moving against Massinissa's capital of [Cirta](#) the king was compelled to return and defend his own kingdom thus allowing Caesar more time to prepare and lending to his upcoming victory. Sittius continued to win victories over Juba, and his subordinate [Saburra](#) after the king returned east, independently of Bocchus.^{[3][4]}